

industry, where exactly does the shoe pinch, where is it that there is a question and a frustration. For instance, I frequently say that when capital has to be raised, if there is a delay at the regulatory end, you can actually miss the timing that you need in the market and that timing may never come back. So that deep sense of frustration that you have with the regulator is something that I've experienced myself. And so, the focus that we have brought within Sebi is to say that every action or inaction or delay or speediness of what the regulator does has a very serious impact on somebody. And that understanding and realisation is also, I would say, the other side of having come from the markets.

**Q:** You are very passionate about technology and data. Why is that so and how has that helped you and, more importantly, Sebi to evolve into a much better regulatory body?

**A:** Technology is what I am passionate about. I would say data and technology... And I think the reason for that is that I learnt many years ago that there is this beautiful, perfect thing called technology that allows you to reduce cost, manage risk, and delight your customer.

40 | Traditionally, these were trade-offs. You either got to delight the customer or manage costs, you either managed to delight the customer or managed risk. Nowhere did we have this ability to optimise on all of this and get that perfect balance of these three. So, to me, technology is really magic. Which is why I am really passionate about it... both in terms of deployment within Sebi, and deployment in the market ecosystem... I am equally passionate about data because I think that the responsibility that you have as the market regulator, where you impact the lives of so many people, is that you cannot have a discussion about your opinion or my opinion. There has to be logic, there has to be data, there has to be a hypothesis, and it has to be tested. You have to do back testing of the impact of what you do. And without that there is no discipline and there is no accountability. So, if you want to increase discipline and the accountability in a regulator, to me, being data-driven and therefore [being] transparent about it, and being able to say to the world that look, we have a point of view based on the data we have [is important]. Now if the data changes, we will change our view. That is the discipline that we need to have. That is what, again, I feel very passionate about.

**Q:** You are the first female chairperson of Sebi. In that context, were there any kind of challenges you faced?

**A:** At ICICI [group, her previous employer], gender was



**"If even 60-65 per cent of what has been created over the last few years stays and gets institutionalised and cemented further [after the end of my tenure], I will be delighted"**

not a thing. You were a professional. You had a role to play... I didn't find it very different at Sebi. So, gender was never a thing for me. I had a great boss. He was very empowering. Did I see any difference in the way he treated me or treated my three other colleagues? Absolutely not. The way my colleagues interact with me today, do I sense anything which is gender-related? No. So I don't know if I'm just exceptionally lucky on this front, but it's never been a thing.

**Q:** Even when you interact with market participants? In fact, they might be more careful when they deal with you because they know your background...

**A:** The quality of the interaction that I have with market participants, the dominant flavour of that conversation has nothing to do with gender. It has to do with the fact that I have been where they are and that I